

Entering Into Worship

Thank You, Jesus. I thank God for the day He taught me about private worship. Even more, I thank Him because I discovered that the Holy Spirit assists me in offering my soul.

I did not know much about private worship. But I can tell you this: regardless of what your emotions say or how you feel, if you enter the private closet, lift your hands, and begin to worship God, He will come.

My soul consists of mind, will, intellect, and emotions. With my physical man, I contact physical things; I can touch this chair. With my soul, I contact other people through accumulated knowledge, thought, will, intellect, and emotional response.

Jesus revealed that God is Spirit and that those who worship Him must worship in spirit and truth. Through the new birth, my spirit remains in communion with God. His Spirit bears witness with mine that I am His son.

With my body I contact the physical world, with my soul I contact humanity, and with my spirit I contact God. Yet when I begin to worship God, I start by offering my soul. I present the same mind, will, intellect, and emotions through which I relate to other people.

I thought I knew how to worship, but I knew only how to participate when someone led a song. The words supplied my intellect, and the music supplied the emotional momentum. I could sing in a worship service while still hating the person beside me.

That cannot continue in private worship. The Holy Spirit helps you offer the part of yourself with which you make contact with others.

Once I learned private worship, it transformed corporate worship. Before, I let the music provide everything. The lyrics filled my mind and the tempo moved my emotions. Only after learning to worship privately did I truly learn how to offer my soul.

I prayed, "Please, Holy Spirit, teach me how to offer my soul in worship."

As a faith man, I normally do not beg God for what the cross has already provided. But I pleaded for this. His response came through revelation knowledge. He often gives my spirit a complete capsule of understanding; I receive the whole segment instantly, ask another question, and receive another capsule.

The Spirit asked, "Whose presence are you entering?"

When we say, "I love You, God," we address the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, three Persons who are one God. When we say, "I love You, Father," we address the One Israel knew as mighty Jehovah, who is now our Father. When we say, "I love You, Jesus," we address the divine union of the glorified man Jesus and the eternal Logos, the second Person of the Godhead.

The Father planned creation, the Son created it, and the Holy Spirit performs the ministry of regeneration. Genesis says:

| In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

The three Persons acted as one. John distinguishes their roles:

| In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

The eternal Logos stood coequal with the other Persons of the Godhead, nothing diminished in any One. All things were made by Him; He was in the world, the world was made by Him, and the world knew Him not.

So when I approach God with a petition, whom do I worship and how do I approach?

Jesus said of the Holy Spirit:

| He will guide you into all truth...He shall glorify me.

The Holy Spirit brings me into Jesus' presence. Jesus then brings me, with my petition, into the Father's presence.

The Spirit asked again, "Whose presence are you entering?"

The Holy Spirit is within me as heaven's representative, presenting my life before God's throne and guiding me into truth. He brings me to Jesus.

Jesus is my best Friend, Confidant, Savior, Lord, and God. When I carry a petition, He is also my High Priest and King.

The Spirit asked, "How would you enter any king's presence?"

That question taught me protocol. An ambassador entering another nation observes the protocol of its ruler. In one country, he may not look the ruler in the eyes until addressed. Elsewhere, he brings a costly gift or remains silent until invited to speak. If earthly kings receive such consideration, how much more the King of kings?

He asked, "What part of yourself are you offering?"

"The part through which I contact other people: my mind, will, intellect, and emotions."

"That is the part I want you to offer in worship."

In Matthew 6, Jesus says not to imitate those who pray on street corners and in synagogues to be seen. If they had no audience, they would not pray.

Public worship can provide words, music, and emotional momentum while the mind wanders. Jesus would not release me from this point.

At a meeting in Rio de Janeiro, I was asked to minister to young people. Their guitars screamed and everyone shouted. It felt horrible to me and did not resemble worship. After one song, I asked my translator to stop the next one.

I said, "Stop the music. From the inner sanctuary of your own heart, choose your own words and tell God how much you love Him."

I knew enough Portuguese to recognize simple statements such as, "I love You, Father" and "I love You, Jesus." Yet the room became silent. The young people peeked at one another, waiting for someone else to begin. When lyrics and emotion were provided, they were ready to shout and jump. Asked to offer their own hearts, they became self-conscious and intimidated.

The Spirit said, "When you enter the King's presence, can you not respect Him enough to bring your whole spirit, soul, and body? You say, 'I love You, Jesus,' while your mind solves yesterday's problems. Why disrespect your King that way?"

This was my first lesson, and breaking through took time. I felt like frozen beef hanging in a freezer.

I began, "I love You, Jesus. I really love You. I praise You."

After a while, my mind wandered while my mouth continued the lip service. When I realized what had happened, I stopped. I went down the street, so to speak, brought my mind back, and said, "You will respect the King in His presence. I am going to learn to offer you in worship."

Then, with everything in me, I emptied my soul into each statement:

"I love You. I glorify You. I worship You. I praise You."

It is not how many impressive sentences you can invent. That may be intellectualism searching for another clever thing to say. What matters is how much of your soul enters each simple statement of adoration.

Again and again, I gathered my wandering soul and returned it to worship. Each period of concentration became a little longer.

Finally, a reversal took place. Because I had repeatedly brought my soul into subjection, the Holy Spirit rose within, gathered my mind, and brought it under the anointing. I no longer had to struggle. My attention remained with Him.

I am talking about finding Him deliberately, until He comes into your room, pours Himself out, and blesses you so deeply that you wonder where you have been.

The brazen altar stood before the entrance into the holiest place. It corresponds to Romans 12:

Present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.

It also pictures Christ's advocacy. If believers sin, we have Jesus Christ the righteous as our Advocate. If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive because His blood has been shed.

Under the old covenant, animals were slain at the brazen altar, while only the high priest entered the holiest place once each year. Solomon, when he received David's throne, offered a thousand burnt offerings. At tremendous personal cost, he wanted nothing between himself and God as he began judging God's people.

When I offer my soul in worship, I remain at the brazen altar until the Holy Spirit receives the offering. Then He leads me onward into the holiest place and rises within me with heaven's presence.

There is no day on this planet without the potential for trouble. We are nearly always at the beginning, middle, or end of a test, with perhaps only a short interval before another.

Jesus said that the person who hears and does His sayings builds on rock. He promised storms would rise and beat against the house, but He also promised the house would stand. The storm may rage around the person inside without ruling him.

If problems continually remove you from fellowship with Jesus, the devil will simply change circumstances whenever you gain victory and send you into another tailspin.

I felt I had died and gone to heaven when I discovered that my occupation and vocation were the same. From the day I was born again and called to ministry, I wanted to remain in God's presence, read His Word, and meditate. Then I discovered that was what He called me to do.

I entered an eight-by-eight-foot prayer closet for three months. I had three little children and mounting bills. Day after day, I remained there under the pressure.

At the end of three months, someone handed me a check for \$736. Five hundred dollars paid the bills, I gave one hundred to God, and kept the rest.

I cried like a baby. I kissed bluebirds, danced in the sunlight, and felt I had gone to heaven. I said, "God, do You mean I can spend my days with You, come out and tell people what You showed me, and that is my work? You will provide for me?"

That three-month battle produced something the devil has never taken from me: unshakable faith in God's faithfulness.

I know how people arrive at church. I once worked fourteen-hour shifts and Saturdays because minimum wage was not enough to clothe my children otherwise. Sometimes the day's weight leaves you wanting to sit and say, "Feed me. Please do something. Do not ask me to participate until God lifts me enough to participate."

God is merciful to worn-out saints. Through consecrated musicians, He may open a channel of grace, move through the congregation, and lift people who entered saturated with the world and nearly dead to spiritual things. He refreshes those who have been fighting lies about provision, healing, family crises, damaged cars, and every other pressure the devil uses.

Sometimes worship sweeps through and people say, "I was drained when I entered, but God picked me up."

At other times, they sing, "Oh, how I love Jesus," while their minds remain on one problem after another. When told to sit, they collapse into the chair.

Just as God can sovereignly release miracles and healings, He can sovereignly release refreshing. But He also wants us to meet Him deliberately in every service.

Remain at the brazen altar, presenting yourself to the King, worshiping and glorifying Him until the soul is truly offered. Then the holiest place opens and His presence answers, "Here I am."

He wants to meet you whenever you will meet Him.

What did I do? I kept retrieving my soul. I refused to disrespect my King with the lip service of those who prayed publicly to be seen.

A person may sing, "Oh, how I love Jesus. To me He is so wonderful," while inwardly hating the person beside him. Private worship exposes that contradiction.

The path forward is simple and demanding: gather the mind, offer the will, intellect, and emotions, and pour the whole soul into sincere adoration until the Holy Spirit takes ascendancy.